

exotic lighting effects, frame them off-centre or try out a different angle. Bring out the individuality in the photograph as much as possible. An important aspect of portraits is to make the subject comfortable rather than self-conscious. Crack a joke, surprise them or give them a compliment just before clicking. The least you could do, as a photographer, is to engage your subject and ask them to smile. Just clicking away “candid” shots while people go about their business is no way to take a portrait – their attention should not be towards something specific out of the frame. Also experiment with expressions. This works very well with young children.

5.4 Landscapes

When it comes to landscape photography, the rule of thirds is most relevant. The rule of thirds is an aesthetic principle, where subjects are better represented off-centre, instead of being right in the middle of the photograph. This means if you are taking a photograph of the horizon, it is more pleasing to set the horizon along the top third of the photograph or the bottom third of the photograph. If you are photographing seascapes for example, positioning the sky for two thirds of the photograph gives a good impression. Similarly, when shooting the layout of the land from a high vantage point, it makes sense to let the land occupy the bottom two-thirds of the photograph.

How the elements closest to the camera are handled or composed into the shot dictates the overall mood and feel of the landscape. This can be a fence, a signpost or a building. Experiment with taking shots that are not at eye level in such cases. If there is a distant object of interest, like an animal or a human being, include them in the shot and compose accordingly. Placing such animated objects in the middle of the landscapes is a good idea, but not a general rule.

In most landscapes, the sky is a very important element. Photographing during sunrise or sunset yields best results. At the same time, the interesting colours are reflected from the ground and the objects on it as well. A bland, naked sky will simply spoil the landscape, especially if there are too many objects cluttering the ground. Make sure that the top half of the image has something interesting.